

The 6:15

MONDAY · SEPTEMBER 21, 2026

NO. 18

THE BOARD

CALENDAR (NEXT 10 DAYS)

Today	NAHB Housing Market Index, 10a ET (Aug. reading was 75). Treasury auctions 3- and 6-mo. bills, 11:30a ET.
Tue 9/22–Fri 9/25	Earnings cluster: 11 reports Tue, 11 Wed, 18 Thu, 2 Fri per Earnings Whispers/Kiplinger — no individual tickers verified this run.
Thu 9/24	Trump hosts Xi in Washington: bilateral meeting + state dinner. Trade-truce extension (truce expires Nov.), AI, Taiwan, critical minerals on the agenda.
~9/25–9/26	Durable goods, final Q2 GDP, existing home sales cluster with initial claims; PCE (~9/26) — dates carried from issue No. 17, still not sourced directly to a BLS/BEA calendar [indicative] .
Mon 9/28	SpaceX targets Starship Flight 14 — first orbital attempt, 26 V3 Starlinks — 8:15–9:30a ET window from Starbase, pending FAA sign-off. Slipped from Tue 9/22.
Tue 9/29	MLB postseason begins.
Sun 10/4	OPEC+ JMMC's 68th meeting — date now confirmed [NEW], resolving issue No. 17's flag.
Sun 10/18	30-day deadline for most measures under the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act to take effect.
Wed 10/28	FOMC rate decision, 2p ET.

No frontier AI model release or VC round fell inside the prior 24–48h window this run (nearest: Anthropic/Google/Meta releases Sept. 1–2, Sling Therapeutics' round Sept. 16 — both outside the window, both skipped per house rule).

METRICS · TIMES ET

Brent / WTI \$101.50 (-2.3%) / \$97.90 (-2.4%), Monday AM trade (Reuters/Bloomberg) — Brent's 4th straight down day, longest losing streak since June. A separate WTI quote

(Investing.com) shows \$93.93 for "Sept. 21 close" — arithmetically inconsistent with Friday's \$100.30 base and this run's own -2.4% figure; **treated as unreconciled, not used.**

2y / 10y / 30y	4.75% / 5.01% / 5.33%, Fri 9/18 (Fed H.15/CME). 2y and 30y confirmed for the first time this run, resolving issue No. 17's flags. The 10y print conflicts with issue No. 17's own carried Friday figure of 4.94% — a 7bp gap between this run's source and the prior issue's, unreconciled.
DXY / VIX / Gold	100.22 (Mon, up from Fri's 99.98) / 14.82 (Mon, flat vs. Fri's 14.81) / \$4,381.40 (Mon), down from Friday's record \$4,415.90.
S&P / Nasdaq futures	+0.6% / +0.8% per one Monday-AM read (Yahoo/Bloomberg); a second read has +0.41% / +0.56% — same direction, magnitude unreconciled.
Asia / Europe	Japan closed for a 3-day holiday (thin-liquidity risk flagged for the yen); broader Asia-ex-Japan equities +0.8%, a third straight advance (MSCI) on US-China talk optimism. Europe: FTSE previewed higher on easing oil; no confirmed close located this run.
Retail gas	\$4.4687/gal natl. avg (AAA, Fri) — carried; no fresher AAA print confirmed this run.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Status	Strait remains effectively closed to commercial traffic. Iran's position this run: no full reopening until Washington meets interim-peace-deal commitments (Sky News, via straits.live) — updates issue No. 17's Oman-claim thread; the temporary Iran-Oman corridor is a narrower, separate August arrangement.
Transits	IMF PortWatch: 8/day, Sept. 13, vs. an 85/day pre-crisis baseline — carried, no fresher PortWatch count located this run.
Dark tankers	straits.live's own methodology note this run: PortWatch counts AIS-broadcasting crossings only, and most of the shortfall "looks like ordinary reception loss rather than deliberate evasion" — in tension with the separate ~57%/peak-65.2% dark-fleet estimate carried

since issue No. 14/17 from a different (Windward-style) vendor.

War-risk premia	7.5%–10% of hull value (S&P Global/Marsh, this run) — firms toward the top of issue No. 16's carried 3%–10% range. \$210M VLCC example: ~\$21M per transit, unchanged.
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Methodology note (every issue): PortWatch's transit count, the dark-fleet percentage, and the hull-value premia range measure different things over different windows — vessel counts, a percentage of a separately-defined "conflict-period total," and dollars — never netted or averaged. No new strait-specific strike confirmed this run; see Iran & Hormuz for a related but distinct Yemen-theater attack.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Lost the Arizona finale 8-4 Sun. 9/20 (Nolan Arenado's third grand slam of the season, off Brent Headrick). 89-66 following issue No. 17's 89-65 through Saturday; hold a wild-card spot with one week left. Postseason begins 9/29.
Knicks	No reported moves. Towns/Hart extension talks remain interlinked and unresolved per the same August reporting carried since issue No. 16 — no fresher item located this run.
Northwestern	No game today. Next: Fri. 9/25 at No. 5 Indiana, first test since the Colorado win moved them to 2-0.

LEAD

CRUDE'S FOURTH DOWN DAY MEETS A MISSILE ON RIYADH

Oil keeps sliding on a supply-and-diplomacy story the Houthis just complicated

Brent is down for a fourth straight session — its longest losing streak since June — to \$101.50 as of Monday morning trade, with WTI off a similar 2.4% to \$97.90. [NEW] The mechanism, per Bloomberg's and Reuters' overnight wraps, is two-sided: signs that Saudi crude supply is recovering after weeks of Houthi strikes on Saudi energy infrastructure, plus investor hope for a diplomatic opening in the US-Iran standoff. [read] "Recovering" here means

output restoration at Saudi facilities damaged or threatened by the Houthi campaign that ran through much of September, not a claim that the underlying conflict has cooled — a distinction the rest of this Lead argues the tape is eliding. [read] Layered on top is a lighter, faster-moving trade: equity futures firming into Thursday's Trump-Xi summit, with S&P futures up roughly 0.5% and Nasdaq futures up closer to 0.7% on preparatory US-China talks in New York over the weekend, where Treasury Secretary Bessent and Vice Premier He Lifeng discussed a new bilateral AI dialogue built around national-security guardrails, tariff cuts on select non-sensitive goods, and the trade-truce extension that is the summit's actual point — the existing truce expires in November. [NEW] Gold's pullback off Friday's record and a flat-to-slightly-lower VIX are consistent with the same risk-on read; so is a third straight advance in Asia-ex-Japan equities overnight. [read]

The complication arrived Saturday, when Saudi Arabia said Houthi forces fired a ballistic missile at Riyadh itself — the first time the Yemeni group has targeted the Saudi capital directly since this phase of fighting intensified — before it was intercepted. [NEW, multi-sourced: Al Jazeera, Houston Public Media/NPR] Saudi air defenses also thwarted attempted strikes on Bisha, Taif, Farasan and Yanbu the same day; the Houthis' Yahya Saree claimed cruise missiles, ballistic missiles and drones were all used. [fact] That is a Yemen-theater escalation, distinct from the Strait of Hormuz itself, but it runs on the same Iran-aligned axis the oil market is trying to price — and it argues against reading "Saudi supply recovering" as "the region has de-risked." [read] Iran's own position on Hormuz hardened in the same window: officials now say the strait will not fully reopen until Washington meets its commitments under an

interim peace deal that has since lapsed — a more conditional, more skeptical stance than the Oman-brokered reopening claim this issue flagged as unconfirmed on Sunday. [DEVELOPING] The temporary Iran-Oman transit corridor agreed in August is a narrower, separate arrangement — reportedly beginning and ending in Iranian territorial waters, with Tehran empowered to bar American and Israeli vessels and fine violators — and was never a general reopening; conflating the two overstated how close the strait actually was to normal traffic. [continuity]

Put together, the overnight tape is pricing an easier supply picture and a friendlier US-China trade backdrop against a Gulf security picture that, on Saturday's evidence, got harder rather than easier. [read] That is the same gap this issue has flagged in prior weeks — markets and the missile count moving in opposite directions — with a new data point on each side: a fourth day of oil losses on the "supply recovering" leg, and a first-ever direct hit on the Saudi capital on the "nothing is actually settled" leg. [read] The summit itself carries its own asymmetry: US reporting frames Xi as arriving with "China's trade engine roaring," which reads as leverage into a negotiation over a truce the US side also has an incentive to extend before November, and CNBC's own preview flags Taiwan as a live topic even though it isn't the summit's stated focus — a wildcard that could move markets Thursday independent of anything oil-related. [read] For a book with Gulf-linked energy or shipping exposure, the read is that this week's real catalyst is Thursday in Washington, not this morning's crude print — but Saturday's missile is a reminder that the tail risk the market is discounting hasn't gotten any smaller. [flag]

Trump signed the Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act into law Friday, Sept. 18 — the bill now carries the name of the late Sen. Lindsey Graham, who died in July. [NEW, resolves issue No. 16's "no confirmed signing timeline" flag] It hands the president tariff authority against top purchasers of Russian energy and countries enabling sanctions evasion, plus new sanctions authority tied to Russia's war on Ukraine, with most measures taking effect within 30 days — Oct. 18. [fact] Passage required assurances the administration would keep discretion over how aggressively to apply it, and Trump's approval reportedly followed the bill's inclusion of a five-year extension of existing Iran sanctions, which he had pushed for. [read] The timing sits awkwardly next to Thursday's Trump-Xi summit: China is among the larger indirect buyers of Russian energy the bill's tariff authority could reach, and how the administration threads that in the same week it wants a trade-truce extension from Beijing is an open question — one none of this run's summit-preview coverage addressed directly. [flag] Separately, the White House's Friday ban on CNN, Politico and MS NOW access remains in effect; no reinstatement, litigation, or fresh reporting located this run. [continuity]

ECONOMICS

Light data day: the NAHB Housing Market Index for September is due 10a ET, with consensus looking for it to hold at August's 75 — not yet in hand as of this writing. [flag] Treasury auctions 3- and 6-month bills at 11:30a ET, a routine bill sale rather than a market-moving event on its own, but one more read on short-end demand a day after this run's newly-confirmed 2y print of 4.75% (see Metrics) and ahead of the heavier data cluster expected around 9/25–9/26. [read] The long end stayed elevated Friday — 30y at 5.33%,

confirmed for the first time this run — which keeps the "higher for longer" duration story intact five weeks out from the Oct. 27-28 FOMC decision, regardless of which of this run's two conflicting 10y prints (4.94% or 5.01%, see Metrics) turns out to be the accurate one. [read] Nothing in the softer housing or claims data flagged in prior issues has been revised or updated this run. [continuity] A hold at 75 would be read as builders shrugging off the elevated long end; a drop would tie directly into the 30y's climb and argue the rate-sensitive part of the economy is finally feeling five-plus-percent financing costs — the print, once it lands, is a cleaner read on that question than anything in the futures market this morning. [read]

BUSINESS

The real business story this week is diplomatic: Bessent and He Lifeng's New York session Sunday was explicitly framed as groundwork for Thursday's Trump-Xi summit, covering trade and investment, AI, the Iran war, and a possible extension of the truce that otherwise lapses in November. [NEW] The AI-dialogue detail — a proposed bilateral US-China channel focused on national-security risk rather than commercial cooperation — is new since issue No. 17 and worth tracking as a possible template for how the two governments handle frontier-model export controls going forward. [read] Critical minerals and tariff cuts on select non-sensitive goods are also on Thursday's agenda per preview reporting, alongside Taiwan as a likely but not headline topic. [fact] Xi arrives with leverage: Reuters' summit preview cites a 25% year-on-year jump in Chinese exports last month and a global trade surplus on pace to top \$1 trillion for a second straight year, more than half of roughly 6,500 US-bound product categories up versus 2025 — a read that Beijing has less incentive to make concessions than

Washington does. [NEW, Reuters via multiple outlets] Markets are already trading the optimism: futures gains this morning are attributed to the summit backdrop as much as to oil (see Lead), and the Tuesday-through-Friday earnings cluster (11/11/18/2 reports, see Calendar) will land squarely inside the summit week, giving the market two simultaneous catalysts to parse rather than one. [read] No confirmation this run of the earlier-flagged Nvidia-Hugging Face deal, the Amazon FTC ad-auction suit, or Ford/CATL battery scrutiny items — all carried as open with no fresher reporting located. [continuity/flag]

GEOPOLITICS

Ukraine launched what Moscow's mayor called its largest drone attack yet on the Russian capital Sunday, timed to the final day of voting in Russia's parliamentary election — a vote Putin has cast as a referendum on war support. [NEW, CNBC] The strikes killed two in the Moscow region and two more in Russian-held Kherson, including an election official, and again damaged a previously-targeted Moscow oil refinery. [fact] Russia's own barrage continued in parallel: 138 attack drones launched at Ukraine Sept. 20, 101 intercepted per Ukraine's air force, with warehouse and vehicle fires reported across Kyiv Oblast. [NEW, single-sourced: Kyiv Independent-style regional reporting] Neither side's numbers are independently verified beyond the attributing outlet. [flag] The election itself produced no surprise: with over 95% counted, Putin's United Russia holds 57.83% (up from 49.8% in 2021, per Central Election Commission figures), turnout 56.66%, and no antiwar party on the ballot after the Yabloko party's removal weeks earlier by the Supreme Court. [NEW, multi-sourced: Al Jazeera, US News, CNN] The timing is notable: Friday's signature of the Graham sanctions act (see Politics) and Sunday's election-day drone exchange put the sanctions countdown and an unresolved battlefield on parallel, not connected, clocks — nothing located this run ties the two directly. [read]

IRAN & HORMUZ

Beyond the Lead's framing, the key update is Iran's own language: conditioning any full Hormuz reopening on US compliance with a lapsed interim deal is a harder line than the unconfirmed Oman-

brokered-reopening claim this issue carried as of Sunday, and it should be read as Tehran's operative position until an Omani official says otherwise. [DEVELOPING] Distinct from that is Saturday's Houthi missile at Riyadh — a Yemen-theater, Red Sea-adjacent escalation on the same Iran-aligned axis, not a Hormuz Strait incident, and not counted in this issue's strait-specific strike tally. [continuity] The first Saudi civilian death attributed to Houthi drone debris was reported the prior Thursday; there is no indication that toll has changed this run. [continuity] The multilateral Salalah meeting that Saudi Arabia postponed on Sept. 13 still has no rescheduled date, and issues No. 15/16's dueling accounts of who asked for the postponement — Iran says Saudi Arabia, Oman's Albusaidi says mutual — remain unresolved. [continuity] Taken together, three separate Iran-linked tracks are now live and moving independently: the Salalah multilateral process (stalled), the bilateral Iran-Oman corridor (narrow, already operating), and Tehran's broader reopening conditionality (hardened this run) — collapsing them into one "Hormuz is/isn't reopening" headline would misstate all three. [read] For positioning: this run's firming war-risk premia (7.5%-10% of hull value, see Hormuz counters) is more consistent with Tehran's harder conditionality than with an imminent reopening, and insurers pricing voyage-by-voyage rather than by standing policy — a practice multiple trade-press sources describe as now standard for the route — suggests the market for physical transit still assumes the status quo persists past Thursday's summit, whatever gets announced there. [read]

SPORTS

Yankees

Lost 8-4 at Arizona Sun. (Arenado grand slam). 89-66, holding a wild-card spot with one week left.

Knicks	No reported moves. Towns/Hart extension talks unresolved.
Northwestern	Off this week. 2-0; next at No. 5 Indiana, Fri. 9/25.

Continuity. Technology cut: no frontier AI release or notable item fell inside the prior 24-48h window this run. No fresher item located on the Nvidia-Hugging Face deal, Amazon FTC ad-auction suit, Ford/CATL battery scrutiny, or the OpenAI-Anthropic Navier-Stokes credit dispute (still unresolved as of Sept. 8-10 reporting, not refreshed this run). CNN/Politico/MS NOW White House access ban (issue No. 17) not refreshed this run; assume unchanged rather than repeated. Watch for next issue: NAHB print and any softening/firming vs. 75; Thursday's Trump-Xi outcome and whether a truce extension is announced; whether Oman ever confirms or denies the original reopening claim; the reconciliation (or non-) of this run's conflicting 10y and WTI prints.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory; conflicting source reads are presented side by side rather than resolved by picking one.